

Benjamin Lebrun

PhD in Psychology | Neuropsychologist

in LinkedIn ■ ResearchGate G GoogleScholar ID ORCID GitHub

📍 University of Canterbury, New Zealand ✉ benjamin.lebrun@pg.canterbury.ac.nz

Profile

French neuropsychologist and PhD in Psychology, my research explores how people perceive “phantom costs” when interacting with robots, including perceived risks and attributions of ulterior motives. I specialise in socio-cognitive psychology, with a background in neuropsychology and cognitive psychology.

Academic Experience

Teaching Assistant in Psychology <i>University of Canterbury</i>	<i>Christchurch, NZ</i>
◦ “Cognition” (200-level paper)	<i>2023 – 2025</i>
◦ “Neuroscience and Neurological Disorders” (300-level paper)	<i>2025</i>
◦ “Introductory Cognitive and Behavioural Neuroscience” (200-level paper)	<i>2024</i>
Research Internship <i>Neuropsychophysiology Lab</i>	<i>Minho, Portugal</i> <i>Aug. – Sept. 2022</i>
◦ Focus on study design for SOBARAG project (Cerebral and physiological differences in social dominance and the creation of social hierarchy towards robots).	
Research Engineer <i>SCALab - Affective and Cognitive Sciences Lab</i>	<i>Lille, France</i> <i>2021 – 2022</i>
◦ Study design for SOBARAG project.	
Research Internship <i>SCALab</i>	<i>Lille, France</i> <i>2021 – 2022</i>
◦ Project: physiological variations during the observation of different types of gestures.	
◦ Responsibilities: Helped with experimental setup, physiological data collection using BIOPAC and EYELINK.	

Clinical Experience

Neuropsychologist <i>Memory Clinic, Hospital of Béthune-Bewry</i>	<i>Béthune, France</i> <i>Mar. – Aug. 2026</i>
◦ Cognitive and neuropsychological assessments with adult populations.	
◦ Geriatrics and neurology. Assessments in the context of research programmes.	
Neuropsychologist <i>Hospital of Boulogne-sur-Mer</i>	<i>Boulogne-sur-Mer, France</i> <i>Sept. – Oct. 2022</i>
◦ Cognitive and neuropsychological assessments with elderly populations.	
Clinical Internships <i>Department of Pediatric Oncology (brain tumor), Gustave Roussy Institute</i>	<i>Villejuif, France</i>
<i>Memory Clinic in geriatrics, Hospital of Douai</i>	<i>Douai, France</i> <i>2021 – 2022</i>

Education

PhD Candidate in Psychology (Testamur link - PIN code: 2026) <i>University of Canterbury</i>	<i>New Zealand</i> <i>2023 – 2026</i>
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- Supervisors: Andrew Vonasch and Christoph Bartneck.
- Project: The perception of phantom costs in HRI.
- Started on 1 February, 2023; Submitted on 31 January, 2026.
- Defence on 20 May, 2026. Testamur conferred on 25 June, 2026.

Master of Integrated Psychology

University of Minho

Portugal
2020 – 2022

- GPA: 4.0/4.0 or 9.0/9.0
- Focus on research in cognitive and social psychology using physiological data. Use of PsychoPy.
- Supervisors: Tatjana Nazir and Adriana Sampaio.
- Project: Perceiving Social Beings in Artificial Agents.

Master of Psychology of Neurocognitive Processes and Affective Sciences

University of Lille

France
2020 – 2022

- GPA: 3.85/4.0 or 8.432/9.0 ([certificate link](#))
- Supervisor: Tatjana Nazir.
- Project: Perceiving Social Beings in Artificial Agents.

Bachelor of Psychology

University of Lille

France
2018 – 2020

- Highest honours ([certificate link](#))
- Supervisor: Loris Schiaratura.
- Project (2020): Emotional Facial Micro-Expressions in Alzheimer’s Disease.

School of Medicine

University of Lille

France
2016 – 2018

Publications

2026

- [1] **Benjamin Lebrun**, Andrew Vonasch, and Christoph Bartneck. “Too Good to Be True: People Reject Free Gifts from Robots Because They Infer Bad Intentions”. In: *International Journal of Social Robotics* 18.5 (2026), p. 58. ISSN: 1875-4805. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12369-026-01395-x>.
- [2] Maria Teresa Parreira et al. “Responsible Outcomes and Operational Tools for Sustainability in HRI (ROOTS-HRI)”. In: *Companion Proceedings of the 21st ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction*. HRI Companion ’26. Edinburgh, Scotland, UK: Association for Computing Machinery, 2026, pp. 1423–1425. ISBN: 9798400723216. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1145/3776734.3793850>.
- [3] **Benjamin Lebrun**. “The Perception of Phantom Costs in HRI”. In: *Companion Proceedings of the 21st ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction*. HRI Companion ’26. Edinburgh, Scotland, UK: Association for Computing Machinery, 2026, pp. 1302–1304. ISBN: 9798400723216. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1145/3776734.3794621>.
- [4] **Benjamin Lebrun**, Christoph Bartneck, and Andrew J. Vonasch. “The Role of Agent’s Anthropomorphism in Shaping Phantom Costs”. In: *Proceedings of the 21st ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction*. HRI ’26. Edinburgh, Scotland, UK: Association for Computing Machinery, 2026, pp. 963–971. ISBN: 9798400721281. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1145/3757279.3788659>.
- [5] **Benjamin Lebrun**, Christoph Bartneck, and Andrew Vonasch. “Plausible Explanations Reduce Phantom Cost Perception in HRI”. In: *Proceedings of the 21st ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction*. HRI ’26. Edinburgh, Scotland, UK: Association for Computing Machinery, 2026, pp. 1278–1282. ISBN: 9798400721281. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1145/3757279.3788804>.
- [6] **Benjamin Lebrun** and Andrew Vonasch. “The perception of phantom costs and personalized HRI”. In: *Reference Module in Materials Science and Materials Engineering*. Elsevier, 2026. ISBN: 978-0-12-803581-8. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1016/B978-0-443-29266-8.00003-7>.

2025

- [7] **Benjamin Lebrun** et al. *People Perceive More Phantom Costs From Autonomous Agents When They Make Unreasonably Generous Offers*. Preprint. 2025. arXiv: [2511.07401 \[cs.HC\]](#).
- [8] **Benjamin Lebrun**, Christoph Bartneck, and Andrew Vonasch. “Phantom Costs in Human-Robot Interaction: A Replication Study”. In: *Proceedings of the 2025 ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction*. HRI '25. Melbourne, Australia: IEEE Press, 2025, pp. 1037–1041.

2024

- [9] **Benjamin Lebrun** et al. “Detecting the corruption of online questionnaires by artificial intelligence”. In: *Frontiers in Robotics and AI* 10 (2024). ISSN: 2296-9144. DOI: [10.3389/frobt.2023.1277635](#).

2023

- [10] Tatjana A. Nazir, **Benjamin Lebrun**, and Bing Li. “Improving the acceptability of social robots: Make them look different from humans”. In: *PLOS ONE* 18.11 (2023), e0287507. ISSN: 1932-6203. DOI: [10.1371/journal.pone.0287507](#).

Presentations

Internet Technology and Data Science Lab (University of Ghent) [Invited Talk] The Perception of Phantom costs in HRI.	<i>Ghent, Belgium</i> <i>June 2026</i>
Symposium for Young Researchers in Cognitive Science [20min Talk] The Role of Agent’s Anthropomorphism in Shaping Phantom Costs.	<i>Lille, France</i> <i>May 2026</i>
HRI 2026 Conference [1min video + Poster + Talk] The Perception of Phantom Costs in HRI.	<i>Edinburgh, UK</i> <i>March 2026</i>
HRI 2026 Conference [Talk] The Role of Agent’s Anthropomorphism in Shaping Phantom Costs.	<i>Edinburgh, UK</i> <i>March 2026</i>
HRI 2026 Conference [Poster] Plausible Explanations Reduce Phantom Cost Perception in HRI.	<i>Edinburgh, UK</i> <i>March 2026</i>
Postgraduate Conference 2025 - CSSE Department [Talk] Phantom Costs Perception in HRI.	<i>Christchurch, NZ</i> <i>September 2025</i>
HRI 2025 Conference [Short talk + Poster] Phantom Costs in HRI: a Replication Study.	<i>Melbourne, Australia</i> <i>March 2025</i>
New Zealand Psychological Society Conference [Poster] Too good to be true: People reject free gifts from robots because they infer bad intentions.	<i>Christchurch, NZ</i> <i>September 2024</i>
Exhibit your Thesis - University of Canterbury [Poster] Epistemic vigilance in HRI.	<i>Christchurch, NZ</i> <i>August 2024</i>
European Society for Cognitive Psychology [Poster] Improving the acceptability of social robots.	<i>Lille, France</i> <i>August 2022</i>
Conference of Embodied and Situated Language Processing (ESLP) [Poster] Improving the acceptability of social robots.	<i>Lille, France</i> <i>August 2022</i>

Service to the Community

Conference Organisation

- **HRI 2027** – Pioneer General Chair *Silicon Valley, USA*
- **HRI 2026** – Student Volunteer *Edinburgh, UK*
- **HRI 2025** - Student Volunteer Chair *Melbourne, Australia*
- **HRI 2024** - Student Volunteer Chair *Denver, Colorado, USA*
- **ESLP 2022** - Support STAFF *Lille, France*

Workshops and Tutorials

- **HRI 2026** – Pioneer
- **HRI 2026** – Workshop: “Responsible Outcomes and Operational Tools for Sustainability in HRI” *Edinburgh, UK*

Reviews

- **International Conference on HRI**: 7 (and 5x 1AC position)
- **International Conference on HAI**: 5 (and 1x 1AC position)
- **International Journal of Social Robotics**: 4
- **Australian Conference on HCI (OzCHI)**: 3
- **International Conference on Affective Computing and Intelligent Interaction (ACII)**: 1
- **ACM Transactions on Human-Robot Interaction**: 1

Academic Leadership

- **Alumni President** *2021 – 2022*
University of Lille, France
- **Presentation of Master’s** *March 2022*
Cognitive Science Forum, France

Skills

Languages: French (native), English (fluent), Portuguese (good), German (previously fluent)

Certificate: Introduction to Programming with MatLab

Programming & Software: HTML, E-Prime, PsychoPy, R

Research Methods: Behavioural experiment design, cognitive and neuropsychological assessment, data collection and analysis, psychometrics

Applied Expertise: HRI, neuropsychology, cognitive psychology, social cognition, behavioural studies, experimental design for social and cognitive neuroscience, quantitative and qualitative analyses

Fundings, Grants, and Scholarships

2026 - 2027: Co-obtained fundings for the HRI27 Pioneer Workshop for a total amount of USD \$ XXX

2023 - 2026: University Doctoral Scholarship

2022: Research Mobility Grant - supported by the French government through the Program “Investissements d’avenir” managed by the National Research Agency.

Prizes and Awards

2026 – Student Volunteer Award: Day Captain | HRI26

2025 – 2nd Place Best Presentation Award | CSSE Postgraduate Conference

2025 – Honorable Mention | HRI’25 - Pioneer Paper | “Skepticism about Robots’ Implausible Statements”

2024 – Research Student Publication Prize | University of Canterbury

Press

- <https://www.cnrs.fr/en/press/less-human-robots-are-more-readily-accepted>
- <https://www.canterbury.ac.nz/news-and-events/news/2024/online-surveys-under-threat--how-ai-can-corrupt-society->
- <https://insidegovernment.co.nz/canterbury-researchers-find-bot-spotting-lacking/>

Membership

- ACM Professional Member

Hobbies

- Collection of meteorites, fossils, minerals | Ex-member of the “Société Astronomique de France”
- Running, hiking
- Coffee latte art

Referees

Andrew Vonasch

PhD Thesis Main Supervisor
University of Canterbury
Psychology, Speech, and Hearing
[Email](#)

Christoph bartneck

PhD Thesis Co-Supervisor
University of Canterbury
Computer Science & Software Eng.
[Email](#)

Tatjana Nazir

Master’s Thesis Supervisor
University of Lille
SCALab
[Email](#)